

Chapter 57-1: 失落 (Loss)

The unexpected scene left Ning Fuyi stunned in place for a while. Soon her arms became sore, so she quickly put the stone-weight-like Bai Lin back on the ground, supported herself against the railing, jumped out, and landed beside Chu Qingqiu.

"You don't even know what happened at Qi Mountain, so why do you want to go with me?" Ning Fuyi was puzzled. "Besides, didn't you just suffer an injury?"

Chu Qingqiu made an "mm" sound, clasping her hands behind her back as she faced her: "What happened at Qi Mountain?"

Chu Qingqiu's question was calm and sincere, but it actually stumped Ning Fuyi.

"Uh..." Ning Fuyi repeated Elder Pingyao's words.

"Then that's settled. The mortal realm isn't particularly dangerous territory anyway, and my injury is nothing serious." Chu Qingqiu replied, her beautiful face tilting slightly to one side.

The meaning was: aren't we leaving yet?

Ning Fuyi couldn't say much more. Besides, even if Chu Qingqiu was injured, having her along always made her feel more at ease. So she didn't object further and crouched down to pat Bai Lin's head.

Bai Lin's barbed tongue licked across Ning Fuyi's palm, then leaped into the air. Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu simultaneously transformed into points of light and settled steadily on its back.

Just like that, they set off for Qi Mountain without further ado.

Bai Lin truly lived up to being one of the four great divine beasts—its speed was countless times faster than sword flying. What should have been half a day's journey was compressed into an hour and a half. Ning Fuyi had only meditated briefly on its back before they had already entered Qi Kingdom's territory.

Qi Kingdom was indeed a place of beautiful mountains and waters. Even though no sun was visible in the sky at the moment, the scenery remained magnificent. Flowers, grass, and trees had been washed fresh and clean by the rain, and the crisscrossing rivers converged into a rushing stream that flowed eastward into the sea.

When they flew to within a dozen li of the capital city, they had already passed beyond the area shrouded in dark clouds. Bai Lin descended below the cloud layer, and golden walls and pavilions came into view below—thousands of gates and ten thousand households in brocade splendor, bustling crowds, and golden carriages.

"Qi Kingdom truly deserves to be called a prosperous land. Just looking at it, you can tell it's different from other mortal places." Ning Fuyi couldn't help but admire.

Chu Qingqiu, standing upright beside her, called out to Bai Lin. Its body slowly descended while gradually shrinking smaller and smaller until it disappeared in mid-air.

Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu's figures descended together into the crowd. They had landed right in the capital's busiest marketplace. Unlike other prosperous cities they had visited before, this place favored red bricks and green tiles. Even the common gathering places had an imperial dignity befitting the feet of the Son of Heaven.

After landing, the two concealed anything about themselves that seemed inhuman—this was a sect rule. Although mortals knew of cultivators' existence, unless under special circumstances, immortal cultivators absolutely could not casually reveal their identities and cause upheaval in the mortal world.

So in fact, although most mortals knew the immortal realm existed, from birth to death, they had never actually witnessed an immortal.

"Divine Venerable, stay close to me so we don't get separated." Ning Fuyi instinctively pulled her sleeve, drawing her closer to herself.

"No need for honorifics in the mortal realm."

"Yes, Auntie." Ning Fuyi deliberately tried to provoke her.

Seeing Chu Qingqiu suddenly stop in place with a displeased expression, Ning Fuyi secretly smiled and corrected herself: "Yes."

"No proper form." Chu Qingqiu said quietly. "Do you know where Liu Wenzhu is?"

Ning Fuyi seriously shook her head and secretly took out her transmission plaque, intending to contact Liu Wenzhu. Suddenly, a tall figure behind them squeezed past the two of them, hurriedly pulling someone through the crowd.

Ning Fuyi was pushed and staggered, wondering how this person had such great strength. Then a group of servant-like people followed one after another, rushing past them and scattering them even more. Chu Qingqiu kept dodging, her petal-like lips pressed tightly together—clearly showing her impatience.

Ning Fuyi wasn't one to indulge others and was about to step forward to argue when Chu Qingqiu reached out and grabbed her sash: "Forget it. Finding Liu Wenzhu is more important."

"Always encountering such rude people." Ning Fuyi patted the wrinkles in her clothes from being jostled, then glanced sideways and suddenly frowned. "Why do I feel like this person looks familiar?"

"Hm?" Chu Qingqiu responded with a nasal sound.

"I think... it's the Liu family head." Ning Fuyi searched her memory for a vague impression. Once she thought this way, the more she looked, the more similar it seemed.

In her previous life, she had only seen the Liu family head twice—once when she was dying and he came to her aid, and once when she saw his aged back at the grave after Liu Wenzhu had fallen into the raging fire.

At that time, she had already fallen to the demonic path and didn't dare appear before him, only daring to watch from afar. So although they had met twice, she truly didn't know exactly how many noses and eyes he had.

"If that's the case, then let's take a look." Chu Qingqiu's words interrupted her memories. When she looked up again, she had already stepped forward, and Ning Fuyi hurried to follow.

The man was followed by a group of attendants, and beside him was a handsome young man he was pulling along. They had concealed their auras, so it was impossible to tell if they were mortals.

The two turned a corner in front of a wine house and entered. The wine house had a gold-inlaid plaque, wide and clean steps at the entrance, and several people in long robes greeting them at the door.

"Two young ladies, are you here for a meal or lodging? Private room or common dining?" Someone warmly approached, bowing as they led the two inside.

Seeing that group go upstairs, Ning Fuyi spoke up: "Private room."

"Right away, please follow me!" Immediately two more people rushed out, smiling broadly as they led them upstairs.

Ning Fuyi surveyed this wine house—both the décor and food were first-class luxurious, clearly not a place ordinary people could afford. Yet even so, business was very good. Perhaps because it was dinnertime, the hall was packed with people.

The leading man and handsome young man entered a room by the corridor. Ning Fuyi had planned to glance inside as they passed the door, but just as she took a step, she heard a delightful voice ring out, warm and gentle, filled with joy: "Yiyi¹!"

She could recognize that voice even if it turned to ashes. Her lips naturally curved into a smile as she turned her skirt: "Wenzhu."

Liu Wenzhu had already risen from the table, avoiding the handsome young man who had been talking with her, and quickly approached Ning Fuyi, taking her hand: "How did you come? Where did you come from—the sect or..."

"I returned to the sect long ago. I heard from Elder Pingyao that your mission here wasn't going smoothly, so I came with the Divine Venerable to assist you."

After hearing this, Liu Wenzhu finally noticed Chu Qingqiu standing far behind them. She immediately put away her smile and lowered her head respectfully: "This disciple greets the Divine Venerable."

Then she exchanged a surprised look with Ning Fuyi and hurriedly gestured for them both to enter.

Footnotes:

1. **衣衣 (Yiyi)** - Liu Wenzhu's affectionate nickname for Ning Fuyi, derived from the "衣" character in her name "拂衣" (Fuyi).